

Fill in the Blank

What is it?

Fill in the Blank is a back-and-forth interaction that gives the child an opportunity to use a familiar word or sound to finish a phrase the caregiver started.

Caregivers are using **Fill in the Blank** when they pause before a word in a familiar story, song, or phrase to give the child an opportunity to say the missing word or phrase, or react in some other way.



Why is it important?

Planning a delay during a predictable routine with a child can encourage communication.

Children can demonstrate what they know and can say.

It provides children with the opportunity to practice communication while having fun **filling in the blank**.

It emphasizes the child's success when they know what word to use to fill in the blank.

Filling in the blank uses familiar phrases and situations to encourage quiet children to speak.

Getting Started

Have you ever noticed how excited children get when you use the phrase, "Ready, set, go!" Sometimes we tease by waiting a bit to say "go" and get giggles from the children as they get ready for what comes next. Or, think about when you play "I'm going to get you" with a baby, and they kick and coo as you pause and hold up your hands to tickle. Even from a very young age, children know what to expect in familiar routines, and we can use these routines to encourage communication through a strategy called

Fill in the Blank.